

The coach who shaped a champion attack

How P. Krishnakumar engineered one of the **most formidable** bowling units in Ranji Trophy this season.

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P. Krishnakumar has worked silently and tirelessly to hone J&K's bowling unit. He was roped in by Mithun Manhas, who was convinced he was the man for the job. "I am indebted to Mithun," said Krishnakumar.

Krishnakumar first saw Auqib Nabi at the team nets during the 2023-24 Buchi Babu tournament in Chennai. "I was stunned by his wrist position. It was strong and firm. His ball skidded, and what impressed me was the speed at which he could bowl long spells without stress. He had a splendid outswinger, and I told myself the team had found a winner."

Nabi never had a coach and was blessed to find one in Krishnakumar. "It was a challenge, but I enjoyed it," said Krishnakumar. "I conducted specific sessions for Nabi and the rest, too, to enable them to understand the playing conditions, the pitch and the biomechanics required to make the best use of their craft. The best thing about Nabi was that he never said NO, and that made my job all the more enjoyable."

Golden advice: A highlight of Krishnakumar's (second from left) coaching is teaching his students the importance of releasing the ball the right way. K. MURALIKUMAR

A highlight of Krishnakumar's coaching is teaching his students the importance of releasing the ball the right way. "You have to feel the ball. With regular practice, the boys were able to master this skill. It came from hard work and their desire to deliver. Nabi, especially, has a natural ability to land the ball on the seam, like (Mohd.) Shami. Nabi is lethal with the semi-new ball. He has a simple, ideal action. The J&K bowlers have a dot-ball percentage of 70, which means the batters have to constantly play the ball. It made a huge difference."

Krishnakumar taught the bowlers to remain calm. "There were times when things didn't work for them, but they did not panic. The bowlers put in a bit extra. The fast bowlers were happy to bowl long spells. Nabi, in particular, never missed a practice session and has played more than 50 matches for the team. I was careful in managing their workload; I just couldn't afford an injury to any of them." As a coach, Krishnakumar